

1939–1946

MENSWEAR ON CIVVY STREET

Britain's austerity regulations and the American General Limitation Order L-85 had a greater effect on women's fashion than on men's. Menswear features such as patch pockets, "fancy backs", trouser cuffs, and the buckles on waistcoat adjusters were abandoned, but this did not make much difference to the wide-legged, long-coated silhouette. More important were wartime shortages, which played their part in the demise of different suit types for different occasions. Even before the war, an ample wardrobe had been beyond the reach of most men. Now demobilized servicemen were issued with one "civvy" suit only, and opinion differed on whether the, usually, good-quality cloth made up for the poor fit. Clothes-conscious youth cultures began to emerge – the male Latinos of Los Angeles and the *Petits Swings* or *Zazous* of occupied Paris used fabric-consuming drape shapes, wide peg trousers, and low-slung key chains to signal their disaffection.

SPIVS AND WIDE BOYS



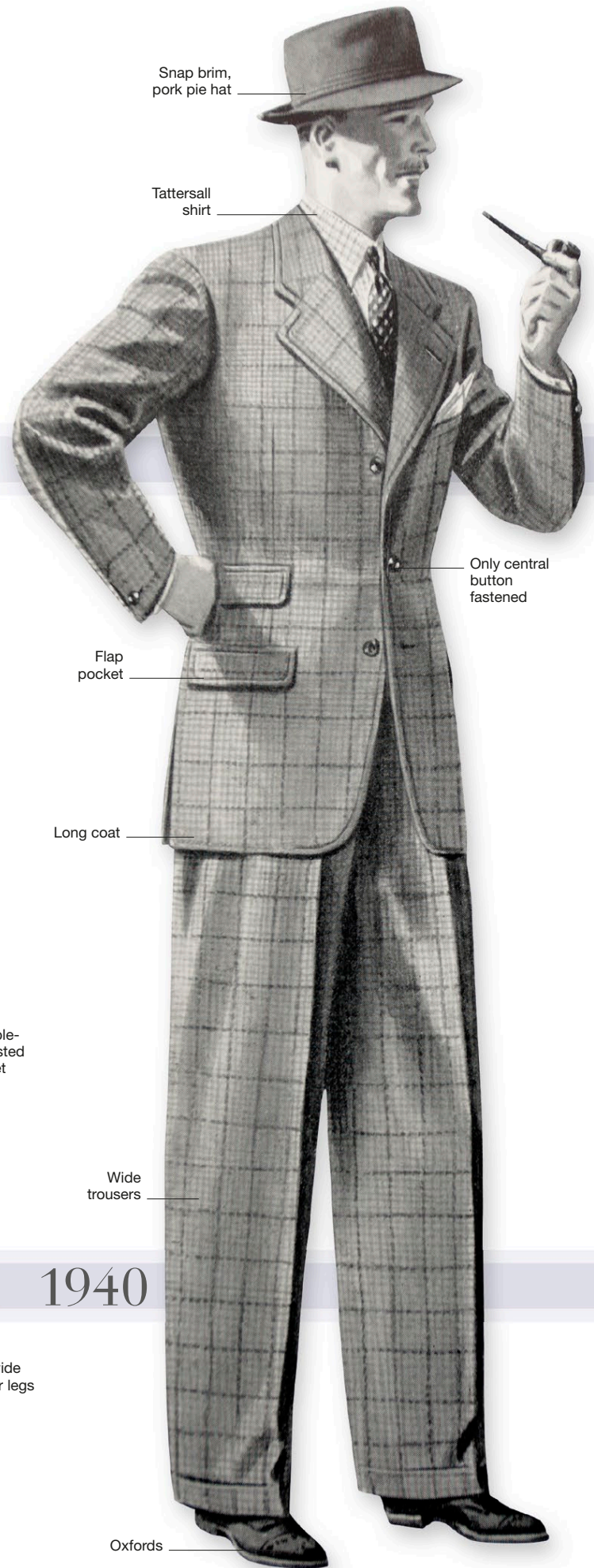
The origin of the word "spiv" applied to a salesman is unknown, but the similar term "wide boy" could come from a penchant for thickly striped suits, generous lapels, or wide, showy ties. A British phenomenon, spivs waited on street corners, especially in London's East End, for business that would come their way. The spiv of wartime cartoons wore his suits double-breasted, his soft hat angled, and his moustache neatly trimmed.

1939



Parisian casual The flat cap and slightly ill-fitting suit, worn with a sweater instead of a waistcoat, by this young French civilian in the first year of the war suggest that he is a man of slender means.

1940

Snap brim,
pork pie hatTattersall
shirtOnly central
button
fastenedFlap
pocket

Long coat

Wide
trousers

Oxfords

Sports suit The checked fabric used for this single-breasted suit signals its suitability for informal occasions only. It was recommended in the English gentleman's magazine *Pall Mall Fashions* for Autumn/Winter 1940.